

## **Designing my Portfolio**

Designing a personal portfolio was on my to do list so going into this project I was excited to make one from scratch. I started the process by examining other tech portfolios to gather inspiration and develop a sense of what I wanted my own portfolio to look and feel like. I used a GitHub repository by Emma Bostian created in 2025 which compiled links to hundreds of portfolios, giving me a broad spectrum of website designs. I also found a list of 24 web developer portfolios published in January 2026 on Hostinger. After doing some research, I decided I wanted my portfolio to prioritize navigation, organization and aesthetics.

The primary audience for this portfolio is tech job recruiters. Portfolios serve as a way to showcase your work, and in this case I will likely be submitting mine directly in job applications. Because recruiters often do not have time to thoroughly read through every portfolio they receive, I wanted to make sure mine was easy to navigate and scannable. This audience consideration strongly shaped how I thought about my website navigation and specifically my home page as it makes the first impression on the viewers. Some portfolios I reviewed had really fun concepts but were not practical to navigate. For example, a game developer's portfolio from the Hostinger website had the viewer drive a little car and parts of the portfolio popped up on the ground as the viewer drove by. This was a cool concept but the speed of the car and the fact that the content was hidden until the viewer got close made it really difficult to quickly view the content. So rather than designing a site that was interesting to explore, I aimed to create pages that were both appealing and easy to gather information from quickly.

One feature I found especially helpful when reviewing other portfolios was the navigation bar at the top of a page. Some portfolios were designed as a single long scrolling page, but I found that navigation bars made it significantly easier and faster to move through a

portfolio. Because of this, I made sure that every page on my portfolio includes a navigation bar at the top. I also added a visual site map with links to every page in the footer so that if a viewer scrolls to the bottom of the page they're able to continue onto another page without having to scroll back up to the top. My footer also includes a link to my site map HTML page, and linked icons that take the viewer to my GitHub, LinkedIn, and Gmail. Both my navigation bar and my footer use anchor tags to link to the main pages of my portfolio: Home, About Me, Experience, Projects, and Resume. In CSS, I styled the navigation bar using Flexbox by setting the display property to flex, which establishes the element as a flex container. The anchor elements inside the navigation bar become flex items and are automatically arranged along the main axis in a horizontal row (Coyier, 2013). The footer uses the same CSS with the addition of the flex-direction property set to column, which stacks the anchor tags vertically rather than horizontally (Coyier, 2013). I played around with the positioning of the links and icons on the footer but ultimately decided that having everything centered looked best.

Another feature I liked seeing in portfolios was the use of box-style cards to organize content like projects and events. W3Schools provided helpful short code snippets to explain how CSS grids work, which I referenced while building my layout. I created two main grid templates that I reused throughout my portfolio. The first is a single-column grid and the second is a two-column grid. I implemented both by setting the display property to grid and using grid-template-columns to determine column sizing. For the single-column grid, I set the grid-template-columns to 1fr, where "fr" stands for fractional unit, making the column take up the full available width (Yossef 2026). To prevent the column from stretching too wide on large screens, I added a max width of 1,000 pixels and centered the content. For the two-column grid, I used the repeat function and set the grid-template columns to repeat(2, 1fr), meaning that each

row contains two equally sized columns that together span the available screen width. The repeat function keeps the grid flexible, making it easy to add new rows of content in the future without having to remake an entire grid (Yossef 2026). I also applied a max-width of 1,400 pixels to this grid so that any text within the columns does not span the entire screen width, making it easier for viewers to read.

For my home page, I used the two-column centered grid. The left column contains a portrait photo of me, and the right column contains my name, a short blurb about myself, two buttons linking to my About Me and Projects pages, and a row of six icons representing my technical skills such as Java and Figma. After reviewing other portfolios, I noticed there was a common layout. Homepages typically had a photo or avatar of the person, their name, and one or two sentences describing their specialization. Some people illustrated avatars, but I felt that a real photo was more personal and useful from a recruiter's perspective. I specifically designed the right column so that the viewer's eye would naturally move from my name, to the brief introduction, glance at my skills, and then be given two options to explore further.

My About Me page includes another photo of myself, this time using the float property to wrap text around the image so that the layout remains clean and readable across device sizes. I used this page to go deeper into my academic background and leadership experience as the former president of the Women in Computing Science (WiCS) organization which I linked with an anchor tag to my Experience page. I originally included links to my GitHub, LinkedIn, and email on this page but after looking at other portfolios and experimenting with placement, the links made the layout feel uneven regardless of where I placed them. I ultimately moved the links to the footer, where they would appear more consistently across every page.

I used the single-column grid layout for my Experience page to document my work with the WiCS organization. I used the box-card format to keep each event visually separate and easy to scan. I used the single-column layout here because each event card needed to be large enough to hold a photo collage, which required more horizontal space than the two-column format allowed. I created the photo collages in Paint 3D and embedded one in each event card to easily showcase multiple photos for each event, making the page feel much more full and vibrant.

My Projects page uses the two-column grid to display my CS projects. I initially experimented with a grid layout of three columns, but after having another student review the page we agreed that the two column format worked better for smaller screen sizes and felt less cluttered overall. To make the Projects page feel more dynamic, I recorded GIFs of each project in action. While I used photo collages for my Experience page, I felt that a GIF would be more effective at conveying what each project actually does better than a screenshot. In addition, for each project I included the title, which linked to the GitHub repository for the project, followed by a description that leads with key details like time duration, team size, and tools used, so recruiters can scan the most important information at a glance.

I designed my Resume page to be a concise, all-in-one summary of the information covered across my site. It includes my contact information, professional summary that mirrors my About Me page, a list of skills and tools drawn from my Projects Page, my experience in WiCS and my current job, and links back to the selected projects I want to highlight. I also added a button at the bottom allowing recruiters to download a PDF version of my resume if they want to save or print it.

Throughout the process of developing my website I thought about what I needed to have present now versus what I might want to add on later. The pages I built, Home, About Me,

Experience, Projects, and Resume, are the core content that any recruiter would expect to find. However, because I used the repeat function in my CSS grids, I can add new projects and experience entries by simply adding new HTML elements without changing any layout code. If I wanted to I can also add entirely new sections in the future such as a blog, contact form, or case studies and the site's navigation and footer structure would make adding new pages straightforward without having to completely redesign anything.

This project pushed me to think about design not just as an aesthetic exercise, but as a communication problem. Every decision required me to consider whether information was necessary, how it could be made more scannable, and where it was best placed on the page. Reviewing other portfolios gave me a strong foundation for understanding what works and what does not, and getting feedback from a peer helped me catch blind spots I would not have noticed on my own.

## References

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